

Question - Discuss Gandhi's experiences in South Africa and how they shaped his principles and strategies for the Indian independence movement. How did the concept of Satyagraha emerge from these experiences? When Gandhi landed in South Africa in 1893, he was an inexperienced barrister, seeking legal career, but when he returned to India in 1915, he evolved into a mass leader armed with moral and political weapons of Satyagraha, Ahimsa and civil resistance which later pivoted the Indian National Movement.

Gandhi's experiences in South Africa -

- ① When Gandhi reached South Africa to defend his client - Dada Abdullah, he witnessed racial discrimination faced by various types of indentured labourers
 - a) Indentured labourers from South India working in sugar plantations.
 - b) Memon muslims from Gujarat (Kathiawar) who immigrated in early 1890s.
 - c) Ex-indentured labourers staying in South Africa after the expiry of contract (usually 5 years).

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② Apart from the racial discrimination faced by Indian diaspora in South Africa, Gandhi himself faced racial acts in various scenarios -

a) Turban incident in Durban - where Gandhi refused to remove his Turban and gained attention for violating prevailing norms.

b) Train incident at Pietermaritzburg - Gandhi was travelling from Pretoria to Johannesburg in a first class AC coach where he was forcibly thrown from the compartment and he spent the night in a waiting room of Maritzburg Station.

c) Johannesburg incident - he was denied accommodation in any hotels as he was termed as "Coolie" by the so called whites. It was a term used for indentured labour from India.

These incidents marked the beginning of Gandhi's fight against racial discrimination through the principles of Ahimsa.

The Rise of Gandhi

① Created Natal Indian Congress (1894) to bring the Indian community in South Africa together to fight for equal rights as British subjects.

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Question- He opposed the discriminatory legislations such as Immigration Law Amendment Act.

② Gandhi's Soccer Genius - He established 3 football clubs with the name "Passive resisters soccer club" to fight racial discrimination. He also distributed pamphlets to spread his principles of Non-violence.

③ Phoenix settlement (1904) - was created in the Natal province, advocating for equal wages and proper work conditions. He also used this to train "Satyagrahis".

④ Satyagraha for against compulsory registration certificates (1906) - Transvaal govt. passed a law requiring Indian and Chinese residents to carry documents and fingerprints.

Gandhi organized satyagraha by passive resistance organization, which even resulted in Indians burning their registration certificates.

⑤ Protest against poll tax and invalidated Hindu, Muslim, Parsi marriages
A Supreme Court order of 1913 declared all

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the marriages as invalid which were not conducted as per christian rites.

Additionally, a poll tax of 3 pounds was imposed on ex-indentured labourers who stayed in South Africa after the contract.

⑥ Protest against Transvaal Immigration Act, 1913 (TIA 1913).

This legislation restricted the Indian diaspora to enter the prosperous Transvaal province from other provinces.

Transvaal March, 29th Oct 1913 - Many workers, labourers marched from the Natal province to the Transvaal province under the leadership of Gandhi. British retaliated by capturing Gandhi along with the protesters. But due to the mounting pressure on British authority, a series of negotiations took between Gandhi, tradinge, General Smutt, CF Andrews which resulted in the "India Relief Act, 1914" that eliminated the poll tax and validated Marriages.

⑦ Gandhi also authored a book - "Hind Swaraj" expressing thoughts on Swaraj, modern civilization, mechanization along with showcased loyalty towards "Moral Empire".

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Question-

If Champaran was the first successful application of Gandhian politics in India, South Africa was the place where the principles forged. Gandhi's philosophy of Satyagrah, Ahimsa, mass movements did not merely make him the face of Indian Nationalism but a statesman who transformed Ahimsa as a "moral ideal" into powerful instruments of "political action".